The Lantern at Gull Point

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Dedication

For everyone who ever kept a light burning for someone else.

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PART ONE: THE STORM

Chapter 1: The Keeper

Mara Quill had kept the lantern at Gull Point for eleven years, and in all that time the light had never once gone dark. She climbed the ninety-seven steps every evening at 6:45 p.m., wound the clockwork, trimmed the wick, and wrote the weather in a leather-bound log.

The village below called her stubborn. The gulls called her nothing at all, which she preferred. On the first night of October the sky turned the color of old pewter, and the barometer fell faster than she had ever seen.

"You'll want to come down to the village tonight," said Tomas, the harbormaster, when he rowed out with her supplies. He was a broad man with a beard like a thundercloud, and he did not like the sea when it was quiet.

"And leave the lantern?" Mara asked. "Not tonight, Tomas. Not ever."

Tomas shook his head. "Dr. Hale says the storm will be the worst in forty years. The Aurora is still out past the shoals."

Mara looked toward the horizon, where the last light was bleeding out of the clouds. "Then the Aurora will need the light more than I need the village."

Chapter 2: The Letter

The storm arrived at a quarter past nine. Rain came sideways against the glass, and the whole tower hummed like a struck bell.

Between windings, Mara read the letter again. It had come that morning with the supplies, sealed with green wax, and it was from her brother Elias, who had sailed on the Aurora three years ago and had not written since.

"Mara," it began, "if this reaches you, I am coming home. The captain says we will round Gull Point before the first frost. Keep the lantern lit for me, the way Mother used to leave the porch light on."

She folded the letter and put it in her coat pocket, over her heart. Then she climbed the steps again, all ninety-seven of them, and checked the flame.

At 11:30 p.m. the wind tore a shutter from its hinges. Mara nailed it back by lamplight, her fingers numb, her hair plastered to her face.

PART TWO: THE LIGHT

Chapter 3: The Signal

A little after midnight she saw it: a flare, red and trembling, far out beyond the shoals.

"Hold on," Mara whispered to the dark water. "Hold on, Elias."

The radio crackled. "Gull Point, Gull Point, this is the Aurora," came a voice, thin and broken by static. "We've lost our mast. We can't see the channel."

Mara grabbed the handset. "Aurora, this is Gull Point. Steer for the light. Keep it on your port bow and you'll clear the shoals by two hundred meters."

"Understood, Gull Point," said the voice. There was a pause, and then, quieter: "Mara? Is that you?"

Her breath caught. "Elias."

"Keep it burning," her brother said. "Whatever happens, keep it burning."

Chapter 4: The Long Night

The flame guttered twice before dawn. The first time, a gust found a crack in the lantern glass. The second time, the oil ran low, and Mara had to carry a fresh can up the stairs with the tower swaying around her.

Old Mrs. Penhallow, who had not left her cottage in five years, stood at her window with a candle of her own. Down at the harbor, Tomas and six fishermen waited with ropes and lanterns, soaked to the bone.

"She'll never hold it," one of them said.

"She's held it for eleven years," Tomas answered. "She'll hold it one more night."

At 4:10 a.m. the Aurora's lights appeared at the mouth of the channel, small and uncertain, but moving in the right direction.

Epilogue

The Aurora came into the harbor at sunrise, missing her mast, her paint, and most of her pride, but not a single member of her crew.

Elias climbed the ninety-seven steps that afternoon. He found his sister asleep in the chair beside the lantern, the log open on her knees.

The last entry read: "Wind northwest, gale force. Visibility poor. Light maintained. All ships home."

He did not wake her. He simply sat down on the top step and watched the flame, the way their mother used to watch the porch light, until it was time to wind the clockwork again.